

Overview of Online Travel Planning

Travel planning shifted from physical agencies to online platforms following the rise of online travel agencies (OTAs) in 1996, beginning with the individual booking platform Booking.com [1]. OTAs aggregate flights, hotels and experiences in one place, use algorithms to personalise recommendations and allow easy comparison of options.

Early online marketing offered customers price transparency through easy comparison across currencies and channels [2]. However, recent research [3] shows customers now face hidden fees, manipulated reviews and fraudulent listings, making trustworthiness and price transparency problems platforms must be solved.

Despite these issues, the global online travel market is projected to grow from US\$540 billion in 2024 to nearly US\$1.95 trillion in 2033 driven by AI, peer reviews, digital marketing, heightened reach, improved customer market position and ease of engagement [4][5][1].

Types of Travel Products and Agencies

Popular OTAs include Expedia, Travelocity, Tripadvisor, and Booking.com. However, package-based platforms differ from individual booking platforms: package-based platforms aggregate multiple travel components using supplier relationships to obtain bulk rates, offering customised itineraries and support for complex trips including group discounts and visa logistics assistance [6]. Individual booking platforms allow users to search, compare, and book single components, focusing on real-time price transparency, user reviews, and algorithm-driven filters. Although users receive less support and must handle their own coordination and disruptions with individual booking platforms, they tend to secure the best individual rates [8].

Packages consist of curated convenience and bundled value for complex and luxury travel [9]. Niche agencies cater to specific travel segments, demographics, or activities, providing curation that generalist platforms may miss [8]. Examples include Thermal (surfing), Winerist (wine tours), and Kidpass (kid-friendly activities) [8].

How Content is Rated and Categorised

Platform observation of Expedia [20] shows that content uses price ranges, sorting and filtering by price, destination tags, and activity categories. Packages and options can be categorised by destination (cities, countries, or regions), which research suggests broadens the global traveller pool [11]. Other categories include activity specialisation, such as BringFido, which exclusively focuses on pet-friendly accommodations [11]. These categories help users find relevant experiences.

Ratings also aid users in finding relevant experiences. While ratings aim to provide an objective assessment of quality, reviews often differ from ratings. Star ratings reflect specific features, whereas review scores tend to reflect those features and additional subjective factors [10]. Verified ratings and reviews ensure transparency by confirming that feedback comes from actual users rather than spam or the company itself, making this an effective trust mechanism [3]. Other trust mechanisms include agency verification and review moderation, which help avoid ambiguous policies, fraudulent listings, and low base prices that exclude taxes and fees—practices that waste users' time on packages they cannot truly afford [3].

Additional Features

Platforms handle group bookings through dedicated online portals [12], shared booking links that allow travellers to book under a group while retaining individual tracking [13], and block bookings with airline discounts and dynamic pricing [14]. For larger groups or those with specific requirements, dedicated support teams manage manual updates [15].

OTAs aggregate data across agencies using web scraping, global distribution systems, and API integrations to collect real-time pricing from multiple sources and competitor platforms [16]. Meta search engines such as Skyscanner and Kayak consolidate rates from various sources, helping OTAs analyse pricing and promotions [17][18]. This data is then structured and analysed to present options in a single interface [19]. Additional price intelligence systems use AI-driven algorithms and machine learning to process aggregated data and enable dynamic pricing [16].

Features that increase OTA popularity include personalisation through advanced algorithms [3], AI integration for streamlined experiences, dynamic pricing, faster chatbot customer service, and mobile-based engagement for greater accessibility [5]. Research also shows that peer reviews and online content encourage users—particularly Gen Z and millennials—to seek unique travel experiences through OTAs [5].

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